Stretcher



Category: **Medical, Healthcare & First Aid** Type: **Short SOP** Priority: **Medium** 4 labs

Covers these lab items: Auto-loading Stretcher; Scoop Stretcher; Stretcher

What it is used for

To move or transfer a person safely using a suitable stretcher. To maintain patient alignment and reduce movement during transport according to the patient's condition and emergency protocol.

Main parts

- Stretcher frame and patient surface
- Wheels or carrying handles
- Safety straps
- Side rails or locking mechanism, if fitted
- Height adjustment or loading mechanism, if fitted

Before you start

1. Assess the patient and follow the applicable clinical or emergency protocol.
2. Inspect the stretcher, wheels, straps, locks, and frame for damage.
3. Confirm the stretcher's rated load capacity and suitability for the patient.
4. Prepare enough trained helpers and clear the transport route.
5. Explain the procedure to the patient when possible and prepare required support equipment.

How to use

1. Position the stretcher close to the patient and lock the wheels where applicable.
2. Use the approved transfer method and sufficient trained helpers to move the patient onto it.
3. Maintain appropriate head, neck, and spine support according to the patient's condition.
4. Secure the patient with the provided straps without restricting breathing.
5. Check that side rails and locking mechanisms are engaged where fitted.
6. Move the stretcher smoothly and communicate clearly among helpers.
7. Monitor the patient during transport and stop if the patient deteriorates or equipment becomes unsafe.
8. Transfer the patient to the receiving surface using the approved method.
9. Clean and disinfect the stretcher after use according to facility policy.

⚠ Safety

- Only trained personnel should perform patient transfers.
- Do not exceed the stretcher's rated load capacity.
- Use enough helpers and approved lifting techniques to prevent injury.
- Secure the patient before moving the stretcher.
- Do not use a stretcher with faulty wheels, straps, locks, or frame.
- Follow spinal-motion precautions and emergency protocols when indicated.

Care & storage

- Clean and disinfect patient-contact surfaces after each use.
- Inspect straps, wheels, locks, and frame regularly.
- Check loading and height mechanisms before use where fitted.
- Report damage and remove unsafe equipment from service.

Common mistakes to avoid

- Moving the patient before securing the straps.
- Using too few helpers for the patient's condition.
- Failing to lock wheels during transfer when required.
- Ignoring damaged straps or faulty locking mechanisms.

Disclaimer: This SOP is prepared from general information available on the internet. For detailed instructions, refer to the manufacturer's original manual / file.

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